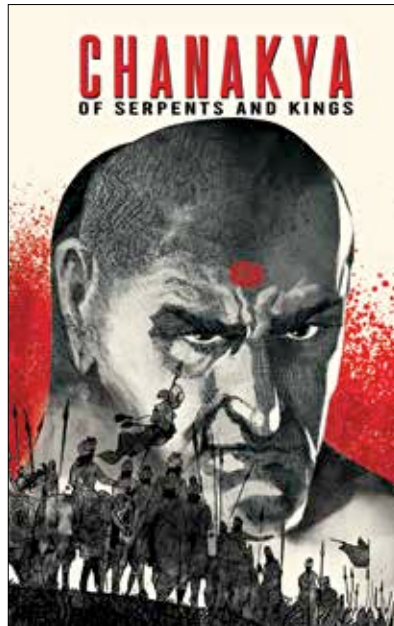


GRAPHIC
NOVEL

Chanakya

★★★★☆ | Chanakya: Of Serpents and Kings is a graphic novel by Campfire that tells the story of the advisor to king Chandragupta, at the time of the ascendancy of the Maurya empire. This book is instantly attractive to anyone with even a superficial interest in Indian history, and it dives right into the psyche of one of the most enigmatic figures in ancient India.

Every page demands your attention. There is a lot to think about, and processing all of it is not easy. The general setting is the rise of king Chandragupta, and the defeat of the generals who have been left behind at the borders of India after the failed attempt of conquest by Alexander. There are plots and intrigues amongst the squabbling nobles. In this version of the story, Chanakya first



comes across Chandragupta as an exile. Then follows a five part story of Chanakya first managing to put Chandragupta on the throne, and then making sure that he stays in power.

While the details in the background are sparse, they have deeply symbolic significance when they are used. The mood and tone of every panel is created very effectively. Each page manages to convey an emotion effectively, whether it wants to show the characters deep in contemplation, or the development of treacherous schemes, or just brutal cold blooded murder. One of the most interesting things is how the skies are used to convey emotions, it is as if the very air is talking to you. This is not a book for the queasy, and many of the themes are mature. This is a dark and mystical volume, brimming with hints and symbolism, dealing with extremely brutal concepts at the same time. Chanakya is both the hero and the anti-hero at the same time, and the book does not shy away from exploring his dark side. If buying for children, it is good to read the book once before deciding if it is appropriate enough. This is not an uplifting read, but is still a rewarding experience, daring enough to tackle difficult notions.

TV SERIES

The Witcher

★★★★☆ | While staying true to many of the aspects of the books and games, the TV series bravely plots its own course. Instead of a morally ambiguous character, Geralt in the series is decidedly morally superior, or at least thinks he is. He refuses to be considered among the humans, and repeatedly takes humane and compassionate decisions in a cruel and unforgiving fantasy world. Despite being in a medieval fantasy setting, Geralt is very decidedly portrayed as the modern day neoliberal hero that everybody needs but nobody is asking for.

Henry Cavill totally owns the character of Geralt, but he is not the only standout artist in the cast. Joey Batey who plays Jeskier (the original Polish name of Dandelion) has a beautiful voice and is a real life lute player. Anya Chalotra as Yennefer of Vengerberg



also has a leading role, and balances out the brooding Geralt by playing an emotional yet powerful sorceress. The performances are very believable, and it is easy to forget that these are human actors playing these fantasy roles. The camera work, set building and CGI are all top notch. Despite a few spectacular

monster hunting and war sequences, the series actually has a slow build up, and takes its time getting you familiar with the characters and setting. This is a fantasy world that does not shy away from showing subtle magic, the brutality of medieval violence, or over the top monsters. If there are any problems, it is with Ciri's track, which is not clarified till the very end, and those not familiar with the source material might struggle with the significance of the events during Ciri's flight.

There is a lot to unpack in the series. Geralt takes the moral high ground in a complicated and divisive world, which is very relevant socio political commentary for current times. There are some unexpected and funny moments, such as when Geralt talks to his horse, or when Jeskier walks away ahead of the Witcher instead of following him. We have tested the series on a hesitant participants, those who don't play games and don't read too many books, they could enjoy the series all the same. This one could go on to become the next big fantasy series that everyone is talking about.